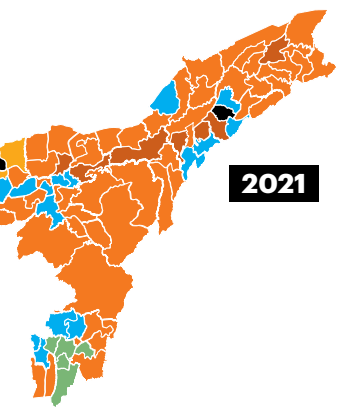


TOTAL COMMAND Himanta Biswa Sarma celebrates the BJP victory, Guwahati, May 4

SAFFRON ASCENDANCY



BJP 60 (33.2%)	Cong. 29 (29.7%)	AGP 9 (7.9%)
BPF 4 (3.4%)	AIUDF 16 (9.3%)	Others 8 (16.5%)

tory had to be emphatic. The BJP's 2026 tally is the third-largest mandate any winning party has secured in Assam's history. In 2011, when the Congress won 78 seats, Sarma had been the architect of that victory, though he had to share credit with the then-CM Tarun Gogoi, father of Gaurav Gogoi. That year, Sarma had pushed for the CM's post. The Congress high command was unconvinced and Sarma crossed over to the BJP in August 2015.

After becoming CM on May 10, 2021, Sarma set about building a state in which his defeat would become difficult. The project had several elements: the man, his welfare architecture, the redrawn map and the identity push

He had been the principal architect of the BJP's victories in 2016 and 2021, too, but neither result was credited to him alone. That changed in 2026, 25 years after he entered the assembly as a 32-year-old lawyer on a Congress ticket. Sarma was the face of the campaign this time. He could not have asked for a better silver jubilee gift.

The Method Man

Sarma's work began the day he took office as CM on May 10, 2021, and started building a state in which his defeat would become structurally difficult. The construction had several pieces: the man, his welfare architecture, a redrawn map and the identity weld. "The BJP has transformed itself into a system characterised by a top-down organisational structure, a cult around Sarma, and an ideological pursuit anchored in Hindu civilisational discourse," says Vikas Tripathi, who teaches political science at Gauhati University. "This systemic dominance has made the electoral space increasingly disadvantageous for Opposition parties in Assam."

Sarma is a politician without an off-switch. He wakes by 7 am and first reaches for his phone, which he describes as his primary tool of governance. Bureaucrats are routinely summoned to his home past midnight to clear files. His day does